



# Beneath a Crimson Banner

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A Total War: Three Kingdoms Modlist for v1.7.2

Three Waves • Three Campaigns • One Destiny

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# Wave 0 — The Warlord’s First Steps

## Roleplaying Background

The Han dynasty crumbles. Yellow Turban rebels burn the countryside, and warlords across the land sharpen their blades. You are not yet among them — you are a minor official, a displaced captain, or a wandering scholar. The world is vast and dangerous. Every decision matters.

Your goal: survive. Learn the land. Build a following.

## Game Setup

| Setting           | Choice                                                             |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Difficulty        | Normal                                                             |
| Campaign          | Mandate of Heaven / Rise of the Warlords (any)                     |
| Faction           | Any recommended starter faction (e.g., Cao Cao, Sun Jian, Liu Bei) |
| Turn Timer        | Unlimited                                                          |
| Battle Time Limit | 60 min                                                             |

## Mods in This Wave

This wave uses only UI improvements and quality-of-life mods. No gameplay overhauls. This is the vanilla experience — polished.

## How to Use This Guide

Read 02-how-to-play.md for a complete beginner’s guide to the game’s systems. The mod list above is installed via TW Mod Manager — see setup-installation-guide.md for instructions.

## Mod List

Example UI Improvement Mod

by ExampleAuthor

v1.0.0

UI

Improves the campaign map UI with better tooltips and information panels.

Load after any total conversion mods.

Example QoL Fixes

by AnotherAuthor

v2.3.1

QoL

Fixes various quality-of-life issues including diplomatic feedback and recruitment sorting.

⚠️ Conflict:

Example UI Improvement Mod → Load after Example UI Improvement Mod

# A Complete Guide to Total War: Three Kingdoms

## The Campaign Map

### Settlements & Resources

- **Commanderies** are provinces containing multiple settlements
- **Counties** are individual towns; assign governors for bonuses
- **Resources** (copper, iron, horses, etc.) provide faction-wide bonuses
- Build orders: prioritize food, then income, then public order

### Characters & Court

- **Characters** are your generals, administrators, and family
- **Satisfaction** determines loyalty — low satisfaction leads to defection
- **Assignments** send characters on missions for bonuses
- **Court positions** grant satisfaction bonuses to holders
- **Marriage & adoption** expand your family tree

### Government & Reforms

- **Reforms** are a tech tree unlocked over time
- **Government type** affects court position availability and satisfaction
- **Corruption** increases with empire size — counter with buildings and reforms

## Diplomacy

- **Relations** affect treaty acceptance
- **Coalitions** are defensive alliances
- **Trade agreements** require a connected route
- **Marriage alliances** bind families together
- **Cooldowns** prevent repeated war declarations

## Battles

### Land Battles

- **Formations:** Shield wall, diamond, spear wall, etc.
- **Terrain:** High ground grants morale and missile damage bonuses
- **Weather:** Rain reduces missile accuracy, fire ammo
- **Morale:** Route units by flanking and general kills
- **Units:** Spear beats cavalry, cavalry beats ranged, ranged beats infantry

### Siege Battles

- **Siege engines** break walls and gates
- **Ladders** allow assault on walls
- **Towers** fire on attackers automatically
- **Attrition** wears down a garrison over time

## Espionage

- **Spies** can be embedded in enemy armies and courts
- **Reveal** enemy spy networks with your own administrators
- **Assassinations, sabotage, and incitement** are available actions

## Economy

- **Food surplus** keeps armies fed and public order high

- **Income** from commerce, industry, and taxation
- **Trade ports** generate significant wealth
- **Reforms** unlock economic bonuses

## Victory Conditions

- **Short campaign:** Own X territories, achieve Y prestige
- **Long campaign:** Control three of China's key commanderies
- **Kingdoms:** Become king, then emperor, then conquer all

## Tips for New Players

1. Focus on food first — starvation destroys public order
2. Don't overextend — one army per front, two max
3. Use spies liberally — information wins wars
4. Keep heirs and generals satisfied with court positions
5. Build roads — trade income depends on connections
6. Save before major battles — learn from defeats
7. Don't trust Sun Jian's peace offers (historical accuracy)

## Zero to Master Training Path

### Phase 0: Setup & Mindset

**Goal:** Start correctly and avoid common beginner traps.

- **Records vs Romance:** Records mode for more realistic battles; Romance for cinematic hero duels. Both are valid — try both.
- **Recommended first faction:** Liu Bei (strong generals + diplomacy) or Sun Jian (safer southern start).
- **Difficulty:** Start on Normal or Hard. Skip Legendary until you've completed all waves.
- **Tutorials:** Turn on in-game tooltips and watch the official Total War Academy videos (linked in main menu).

**Key mindset:** This is a game of characters + diplomacy + economy, not just battles.

### Phase 1: Core Fundamentals

**Goal:** Understand the basic loop and survive the early game.

#### Must-Learn Mechanics

- **Commanderies & Settlements** — Every commandery has a capital plus resource settlements. Food and money are the foundation of everything.
- **Characters** — Five classes: Commander, Vanguard, Champion, Strategist, Sentinel. Each has unique roles on the battlefield and in administration.
- **Assignments** — Put characters as Administrators, in Court positions, or as Spies. Never leave good characters idle.
- **Armies** — 3 generals max per army (with retainers). Learn the difference between Militia and Professional units.
- **Basic Diplomacy** — Trade agreements, non-aggression pacts, and coalitions. Food-for-money deals are your best friend early.

#### Training Exercises

1. Play one full campaign as Liu Bei or Sun Jian focusing only on economy and not over-expanding.
2. Manually fight every battle for the first 30-40 turns so you learn unit strengths.
3. Never auto-resolve important battles until you understand why you win or lose.

**Success criteria:** Reach turn 50-60 without going bankrupt or being destroyed. Understand why food surplus matters.

## First 20 Turns — Liu Bei Campaign Guide

This guide walks you through the first 20 turns as **Liu Bei** on **Normal** difficulty. Liu Bei starts in the northeast with strong generals (Guan Yu, Zhang Fei) and excellent diplomatic options — the ideal learning faction.

### Turn 1

#### Diplomacy

- Send a **Trade Agreement** offer to every faction you've met (Gongsun Zan, Han Sui, Kong Rong, etc.). Accept any that come back. Trade income is small early but compounds.
- Check if any faction will give you money for food. Offer 10-20 food per turn for a lump sum. Use that gold to build.

#### Army

- Merge damaged units. Guan Yu and Zhang Fei start with good retainers — keep them together.
- Move your main army toward **Dong Commandery** (the settlement just south). Do not attack yet — get into position.

#### Buildings

- **Commandery capital (Pingyuan):** Build the first tier of a **Farm** (food production) or **Market** (income). Prioritize food if you're at or below 0 surplus.

#### Characters

- Check your court. Assign any idle characters as **Assignments** — “+10 satisfaction” assignments on your faction leader or heir prevent loyalty problems.
- Set your heir if one isn't assigned. Liu Bei as faction leader, Guan Yu as heir is a strong start.

### Turn 2

#### Army

- Continue moving toward Dong Commandery. If it's unguarded, you can take it next turn without a fight (AI will usually retreat).
- Recruit 1-2 militia units in Pingyuan if you have spare income. Ji Militia (spear) are cheap and effective.

#### Diplomacy

- Check for **Non-Aggression Pacts** with your neighbors. Gongsun Zan to the north is a useful friend — he'll occupy Yuan Shao's attention.
- Offer NAPs for free or for a small payment. Most factions will accept early on.

#### Buildings

- If you built a farm last turn, start a **Market** or **Workshop** in your capital now. Diversify income.
- Build a **Road** in your capital commandery. Roads unlock trade routes and speed up army movement.

## Turn 3-5: Secure Your First Province

### Conquest

- Attack Dong Commandery. If the enemy army is nearby, fight manually — you outnumber them with Guan Yu + Zhang Fei.
- In battle: use Guan Yu and Zhang Fei aggressively against enemy generals. Their dueling skills are excellent. Protect your militia line while the heroes flank.
- After capturing Dong, move to **Puyang** or **Taishan** — your second province target.

### Economy

- Build farms in every new settlement. Food surplus = public order = growth.
- Keep at least one building slot for public order (temples or garrisons).

### Diplomacy

- By now, one neighboring faction may have declared war. Don't panic — they usually want a weak settlement. Offer a small payment for peace if you're not ready.
- Seek a **Coalition** or **Military Alliance** with Gongsun Zan or Kong Rong. A single ally deters multiple enemies.

## Turn 6-10: Expand Carefully

### Conquest Strategy

- Target **one direction only**. Don't fight on two fronts. If you're at war with Yuan Shao to the north and 陶 Qian to the south, make peace with one.
- Capture your second full commandery. This gives you a second building slot for income or recruitment.
- Do NOT take settlements you can't defend. Leave buffer territory between you and strong enemies.

### Army Management

- You should have one main army (Liu Bei + Guan Yu + Zhang Fei). Do not hire a second general yet — the upkeep cost is too high.
- If a second enemy army appears, recruit a **garrison** in your capital (cheap militia). Don't create a second full army until you have two commanderies fully developed.

### Economy Check (End of Turn 10)

- Food surplus: +5 minimum. If below, build more farms.
- Income: +500 minimum per turn. If below, build markets, sign more trade deals.
- Public order: All settlements above -5. Assign characters with "+public order" skills as administrators.

### Reforms

- Research **Agricultural Reforms** (food) or **Taxation Reforms** (income) first. Military reforms can wait.

## Turn 11-15: Stabilise & Prepare

### Buildings

- Upgrade your capital to **Town** level (population 4) if you have the gold. This unlocks second-tier buildings and a garrison slot.
- Build a **Temple** or **Confucian School** in settlements with unrest. Public order is the cap on expansion speed.

### Characters & Satisfaction

- Check every character's satisfaction. If anyone is below 60, give them an **Ancillary** (item), a **Court Position**, or an **Administrator** role.
- Recruit one or two new characters if you have open retinue slots. Look for characters with "+commerce" or "-corruption" traits.

### Diplomacy Targets

- Identify your **first mid-game enemy**. On Normal, this is likely Yuan Shao (north) or Cao Cao (southwest).
- Build spy networks. Send a character with high cunning as a spy into your next target's court.

## Turn 16-20: The First Crisis

### What to Expect

- Around turn 15-20, your nearest major power will declare war or demand tribute. This is normal.
- Your public order may dip as your empire grows. Assign administrators and build temples.
- A random event (dilemma) will test your decision-making. Choose options that favour food or satisfaction.

### Military Action

- If at war, fight defensively. Let the enemy attack your settlements so you fight on favourable terrain.
- In battle: use your generals to kill routing enemies (increases army XP). Keep the main force together.
- Consider recruiting a second army only if:
  - You have +10 food surplus
  - You have +1000 gold in reserve
  - You need to defend a second front

### Goals Achieved by Turn 20

- 2-3 commanderies captured and stable
- Positive food and income
- At least one ally or coalition
- Core army: Liu Bei + Guan Yu + Zhang Fei, at least rank 3 each
- One spy placed in a rival court

### Quick Reference

| Turn  | Priority Action                        |
|-------|----------------------------------------|
| 1     | Trade agreements, move army south      |
| 2-3   | Capture Dong Commandery                |
| 4-5   | Build farms, secure first province     |
| 6-8   | Expand in one direction only           |
| 9-10  | Economy check: food +5, income +500    |
| 11-13 | Upgrade capital, assign administrators |
| 14-16 | Diplomacy: choose next target          |
| 17-20 | Defend first crisis, achieve stability |



## If Something Goes Wrong

- **Bankrupt?** Disband the most expensive unit(s). Cancel all diplomacy payments. Sell food for gold.
- **Attacked on two fronts?** Make peace with one side — pay them if needed. Your priority is to survive, not to win every war.
- **General assassinated?** Recruit a replacement from the pool. Any Vanguard or Commander can fill Guan Yu's role temporarily.
- **Revolts?** Lower taxes in the rebellious province. Build a temple. Assign a character with “+public order” there.

## Wave 1 — The Kingdom Endures

### Roleplaying Background

Years have passed. Your warlord now commands a stable domain — a true kingdom with borders, allies, and enemies. The world is no longer about survival but about expansion. Trade routes stretch across your lands. Your generals are seasoned veterans. But new threats gather at every border.

Your goal: secure your kingdom's future through diplomacy, strategy, and well-placed force.

### Game Setup

| Setting           | Choice                                                            |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Difficulty        | Hard                                                              |
| Campaign          | Rise of the Warlords                                              |
| Faction           | Any major regional power (e.g., Gongsun Zan, Yuan Shao, Liu Biao) |
| Turn Timer        | Unlimited                                                         |
| Battle Time Limit | 60 min                                                            |

### What's New

- **Graphics overhaul** — the world looks richer and more immersive
- **Content mods** — new units, buildings, and events
- **Audio pack** — thematic battle music
- **Mechanic mods** — deeper systems (may affect diplomacy, economy, or spies)

### Strategy Shift

On Hard difficulty, the AI is more aggressive and makes smarter decisions. Read `02-strategy.md` for advanced tactics.

## Mod List

### Example Graphics Overhaul by GraphicsAuthor

v2.0.0

#### GRAPHICS

High-resolution textures for units, buildings, and campaign map.

*Requires high-end GPU.*

# Example Content Expansion

by ContentAuthor

v1.5.0

## CONTENT

Adds new unique units, buildings, and events for several factions.

**Dependencies:** Example Graphics Overhaul

 **Conflict:** Another Content Mod → Load this one first, then Another Content Mod

 Adds unique faction buildings with new recruitment options

*Start a new campaign after enabling.*

# Example Audio Pack

by AudioAuthor

v1.0.0

## AUDIO

Replaces battle music with traditional Chinese instruments.

*Compatible with all overhauls.*

# Advanced Strategy for Wave 1

## Campaign Strategy on Hard

### Early Game (First 20 Turns)

1. **Secure your home commandery** — build the food chain first (farm > market > workshop)
2. **One army, one purpose** — don't split forces early; focus on one enemy at a time
3. **Diplomacy is defense** — use non-aggression pacts to protect flanks
4. **Spies in every court** — embed early, reap intelligence later

### Mid Game (Turns 20-60)

1. **Two-front planning** — by now you have two armies; they should push opposite directions
2. **Governor assignments** — assign characters to rich commanderies for bonuses
3. **Reform priorities** — unlock administrative reforms before military ones
4. **Coalitions** — join or form one to deter large aggressors

### Late Game (Turns 60+)

1. **Kingmaking** — once you become king, expect the "kingdom" diplomatic penalty
2. **Economic consolidation** — ensure every territory generates profit
3. **Elite armies** — replace militia with elite units as income allows
4. **The final push** — three kingdoms remain; choose your moment

## Battle Tactics for Hard

- **AI uses flanking** — always reserve cavalry for counter-flanking
- **Moral shocks** — focus fire on enemy general; loss of general = route cascade
- **Terrain denial** — capture high ground before engaging
- **Siege patience** — build siege engines rather than assaulting walls directly
- **Retreat is an option** — preserve armies, fight another day

## Mod-Aware Strategy

- New units from content mods have unique strengths — read their descriptions
- Audio mods give cues for battlefield events (listen for unique instrument cues)
- If a mechanic mod changes public order or corruption, adjust building priorities accordingly

## Intermediate Systems (Phase 2 Training)

### Court & Government

- **Faction Leader, Heir, and Prime Minister** give powerful faction-wide bonuses. Appoint carefully — don't leave these slots empty.
- Assign characters to court positions based on their **traits and skills**, not just loyalty. A corrupt administrator hurts more than a disloyal one.
- Government type affects available court positions and satisfaction distribution. **Meritocracy** and **Patriarchy** have very different trade-offs.

### Guanxi (Relationships)

- Characters form **friendships, rivalries, and sworn brotherhoods** over time. These affect loyalty, satisfaction, and battlefield performance.
- Pair characters with positive relationship traits in the same army — they fight better together.
- Avoid putting rivals in the same army or court — they will drag each other's satisfaction down.
- Use **marriage** and **adoption** strategically to lock in loyalty from talented generals.

## Reforms Tree

- Prioritize reforms that match your playstyle. Do not research randomly — every turn spent on the wrong reform is a turn of lost advantage.
- **Administrative reforms** (corruption reduction, satisfaction) scale better than military reforms for most campaigns.
- **Commerce reforms** compound over time. Invest early.
- Unlocking **purple (Governance) and green (Commerce) tree** nodes early gives a stronger economy foundation for late-game military pushes.

## Spies & Undercover Network

- Embed **spies** early. The best time to plant a spy is before you need one. By turn 30, you should have at least one spy in your nearest rival's court.
- Secure your spy's position by having them perform **small favours** (reveal army positions) before asking them to **assassinate or sabotage**.
- **Counter-intelligence matters**. Assign a character with high cunning as an administrator in each commandery to reveal enemy spies.
- A well-placed spy can steal technologies, incite rebellions, or assassinate a faction leader — often more valuable than an army.

## Army Composition

- A **balanced army** (frontline + ranged + cavalry) beats pure stacks every time.
  - 4-6 spear infantry (frontline)
  - 4-6 ranged units (archers/crossbows)
  - 2-4 cavalry (flanking)
  - 2-4 shock infantry or special units
- Learn counter units: **spears beat cavalry, cavalry beats ranged, ranged beats infantry, shock infantry beats spears**.
- Keep at least one **Strategist** in your main army for their formation abilities and ranged buffs.
- As your economy grows, phase out militia units for **professional** ones — the stat difference is significant by mid-game.

## Training Exercises

1. Play as **Cao Cao** (best diplomatic tools) and focus on vassals + credibility.
2. Deliberately use spies to dismantle one enemy faction from the inside.
3. Build at least two specialized armies (e.g., one defensive, one aggressive cavalry).

**Success criteria:** Maintain high satisfaction across your empire. Use diplomacy + spies as effectively as armies.

# Wave 2 — Beneath a Crimson Banner

## Roleplaying Background

The empire burns. You are no longer a warlord or a king — you are the last hope of a dying age. Your territories stretch across China, but every border is contested. Generals scheme for your throne. The people grow restless. Three kingdoms stand between you and ultimate dominion, and the world itself seems to conspire against you.

This is the final wave. There is no backup plan. No retreat. Only victory or annihilation.

Your goal: unite China under your banner — or watch it all burn.

## Game Setup

| Setting           | Choice                                                 |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Difficulty        | Legendary                                              |
| Campaign          | Mandate of Heaven                                      |
| Faction           | Any (recommend a faction you know well from Waves 0-1) |
| Turn Timer        | Unlimited                                              |
| Battle Time Limit | 60 min                                                 |

## What’s New

- **Full mechanical overhauls** — diplomacy, economy, and characters work differently
- **Endgame crisis events** — scripted challenges that test your empire
- **Maximum difficulty** — Legendary AI morale bonuses, no battle saves
- **Compatibility considerations** — some Wave 1 mods conflict; read carefully

## The Challenge

Wave 2 is designed for players who have mastered Waves 0-1. If you haven’t completed at least one campaign on Hard with Wave 1’s modset, consider playing more before starting this wave.

## Mod List

Example Total Overhaul

by OverhaulAuthor

v3.0.0

MECHANICS

Complete overhaul of diplomacy, economy, and character systems.

Dependencies: Example Graphics Overhaul

⚠️ **Conflict:** Example Content Expansion → Compatible only with patches from the mod page. Use the compatibility patch.

⚠️ **Conflict:** Vanilla Diplomacy Fix → Incompatible — do not use together

⚙️ Replaces the entire diplomacy system with a deeper offer-and-demand negotiation model. Adds population mechanics to economy. Introduces general loyalty factions.

*Requires new campaign. Read the mod page carefully.*

Example Endgame Challenge

by ChallengeAuthor

v1.2.0

MECHANICS

Adds late-game crisis events, horde armies, and empire-shattering dilemmas.

Dependencies: Example Total Overhaul

⚙️ Adds scripted endgame scenarios that trigger when certain conditions are met (e.g., territory count, prestige level)

*Can be toggled on/off mid-campaign.*

# Expert Strategy for Wave 2

## Campaign Strategy on Legendary

### The First 50 Turns (Survival)

1. **Legendary AI cheats** — AI gets public order and morale bonuses. Plan for it.
2. **No battle saves** — every battle matters. Auto-resolve is more punishing.
3. **Aggressive expansion in the first 20 turns** — cripple your nearest rival before they grow
4. **Accept that you will lose settlements** — plan to retake, not to hold everything

### Mod-Overhauled Systems

#### Diplomacy Overhaul

- The overhaul mod changes negotiation to a offer-demand system
- You must offer something of value for every request
- Trust is a resource — breaking treaties permanently damages relationships
- War declarations require casus belli or heavy diplomatic penalties

#### Economy Overhaul

- Population mechanics: larger cities drain food, generate wealth but require more public order
- Tax rate affects population growth — high taxes slow growth
- Trade route banditry: invest in road infrastructure to protect trade

#### Character Overhaul

- Generals have loyalty factions — they may rebel with their entire army
- Court politics matter: promote talented generals or risk defection
- Family tree management is critical — succession crises can end campaigns

### Endgame Crisis Events

- **Horde armies** spawn from ungarded borders — keep reserve forces
- **Economic collapses** trigger when corruption reaches thresholds — reform down
- **Dilemmas** force choices between short-term gain and long-term stability
- **Rival kingdoms** coordinate against the player — divide and conquer

### Battle Tactics for Legendary

- **Never autoresolve** against equal or greater forces — the calculator is ruthless
- **General sniping** is harder (AI protects generals better) — use cavalry traps
- **Morale management** is key — your units will break faster without your general nearby
- **Terrain is your only advantage** — always fight on favorable ground
- **Withdraw from unwinnable battles** — preserving armies is preserving campaign viability

## Advanced Campaign Mastery (Phase 3)

### Emperor Mechanics

- Once you declare yourself **Emperor** (or another faction does), the game shifts. You gain access to **Imperial Seals** — powerful ancillaries that grant faction-wide bonuses.
- Seals are awarded for achieving prestige milestones. Prioritize prestige generation once you control 60+ territories.
- The **Three Kingdoms** phase triggers when three factions reach King or Emperor status. At this point, the two rival emperors become permanent enemies.

## Vassals vs Direct Conquest

- **Vassals** are useful buffers — they guard borders and contribute armies — but they generate less income than directly owned territories.
- Use vassals for regions with different culture (e.g., Nanman territories) where public order would be a nightmare.
- Direct conquest is better for wealthy commanderies with your culture. Vassalize the poor ones.
- You can **integrate** vassals later, but it takes time and satisfaction penalties. Plan your integration order.

## Satisfaction & Corruption at Scale

- At large empire size (10+ commanderies), **corruption** eats 30-50% of your income if unchecked. Prioritize corruption-reducing reforms and buildings.
- **Satisfaction management** becomes a full-time job. Every turn, check your character list — anyone below 50 satisfaction needs an immediate promotion, ancillary, or marriage.
- Use **Administrators** in every commandery — they reduce corruption and increase income enough to justify their salary.
- The **Prime Minister** position is critical at this stage. Assign your highest-ranking character with “+satisfaction to all” traits.

## Character Skill Trees

- By Phase 3, your core generals should be rank 6+. Plan their skill trees:
  - **Commanders:** Focus on “+satisfaction to all” and army movement range.
  - **Vanguards:** Damage and charge bonuses. They are your field generals.
  - **Champions:** Personal dueling skills and unit buffs.
  - **Strategists:** Ranged damage, formation abilities, and cunning for spy networks.
  - **Sentinels:** Defense, garrison bonuses, and administrator skills.
- Do not waste skill points on redundant abilities. Specialize each general for their role.

## Timing Major Wars

- Do not declare yourself Emperor until you have 3+ elite armies ready. The diplomatic penalty with everyone else is severe — expect coalitions to form against you.
- Break alliances and coalitions **before** declaring war. The trust penalty is worth avoiding the “ally joined enemy” problem.
- Time your wars when your target is already fighting someone else. Let them exhaust their armies, then strike.

## Training Exercises

1. Play a full campaign where you deliberately become Emperor as late as possible while still dominating the map.
2. Run a “tall” campaign (few high-quality commanderies) vs a “wide” campaign (rapid expansion).
3. Master the **Yellow Turban** or **Nanman** factions for completely different playstyles.

**Success criteria:** Reliably win on Hard/Very Hard. Understand **why** the AI makes certain diplomatic moves.

## Battle Mastery & Micro (Phase 4)

### Focus Areas

- **Terrain usage:** Forests block line of sight and reduce missile damage. Hills give morale and damage bonuses. Rivers slow movement and exhaust units. Choke points negate numerical disadvantages.

- **Flanking:** A unit attacking an enemy from the side or rear deals massive morale damage. One flanking cavalry charge can route an entire unit.
- **Cycle charging:** Charge, pull back, charge again. Cavalry that stays in melee loses its charge bonus. Micro your cavalry for maximum impact.
- **Hero duels (Romance mode):** Duels can swing battles instantly. Send your champion against enemy generals but pull them back when outmatched. In Records mode, general bodyguards are powerful but not invincible — use them as heavy cavalry.
- **Strategist abilities:** Fire arrows, smoke screens, and night battles are force multipliers. Use them.
- **Army stances:** March (faster but cannot retreat), Ambush (invisible until attack), Raiding (sustain without supply), and Forced March (extra range but exhausted in battle). Use the right stance for the situation.

### Training Method

1. Replay the same historical battle (e.g., Guandu-style scenarios) multiple times with different army compositions.
2. Practice fighting 1.5x-2x larger armies on the battle map.
3. Watch high-level campaign battle footage and pause to analyze decisions.

## Master Level — Legendary & Optimisation (Phase 5)

### Legendary Difficulty Adjustments

- **No battle saves** — every battle matters. Auto-resolve is more punishing than manual battle.
- **AI morale bonuses** — enemy units take longer to break. Plan for extended fights.
- **AI public order cheats** — the AI expands faster without rebellion. Do not try to out-expand them — out-smart them.
- **Minimal reloading** — embrace mistakes. Legendary is about adaptation, not perfection.

### Min-Maxing Your Empire

- **Character traits:** Recruit and promote characters with “+satisfaction,” “-corruption,” and “+commerce” traits. Remove or demote characters with negative traits.
- **Ancillaries:** Every character should have a full ancillary loadout. The bonuses compound. Trade for ancillaries in diplomacy if needed.
- **Court synergy:** Certain combinations of court positions + character traits create powerful synergies. For example, a Prime Minister with “+2 satisfaction to all” plus an Heir with “-10% corruption” nearly solves two problems at once.
- **Army specialisation:** By late game, build specialized armies — one for siege, one for field battles, one for rapid response. Don’t make every army a generalist.

### Final Challenges

1. Win a Legendary campaign as a hard starting faction (Kong Rong, Liu Biao, or a Yellow Turban).
2. Unify China before turn 100 on Very Hard/Legendary.
3. Play a full campaign with self-imposed restrictions (no spies, no vassals, only one army type, etc.).

## Learning Resources

| Resource                                    | Best For  | Notes                              |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------|------------------------------------|
| Total War Academy (in-game / official site) | Phase 0-1 | Official short videos              |
| ItalianSpartacus YouTube                    | Phase 1-2 | Excellent beginner campaign guides |
| Serious Trivia YouTube                      | Phase 2-4 | Deep mechanical analysis           |



|                      |            |                                |
|----------------------|------------|--------------------------------|
| LegendofTotalWar     | Phase 3-5  | High-level Legendary campaigns |
| In-game Encyclopedia | All phases | Always keep it open            |

## Suggested Campaign Progression

1. **Liu Bei or Sun Jian** (Normal) — learn the basics
2. **Cao Cao** (Hard) — learn diplomacy & manipulation
3. **Any faction you like** (Very Hard) — apply everything
4. **Hard starting faction** (Legendary) — master level

## Appendices

### Mod Installation Guide

## Setup & Installation Guide

### Total War Mod Manager (TWMM)

TW Mod Manager is the recommended tool for managing Total War: Three Kingdoms mods.

#### Download & Install

1. Visit <https://www.nexusmods.com/site/mods/1238>
2. Download the latest version
3. Run the installer
4. On first launch, point TWMM to your Total War: Three Kingdoms installation folder (typically `steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS`)

#### Importing a Modlist

Each wave directory contains a `mods.yaml` file listing all mods and their sources.

1. Download each mod from its Nexus/Steam Workshop URL
2. Place `.pack` files in `Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/`
3. Open TWMM — it scans the data folder and lists all detected mods
4. Check the mods you want to enable for your current wave
5. Arrange load order (see below)

#### Load Order Rules

1. **Dependencies before dependents** — if Mod B needs Mod A, Mod A loads first
2. **UI mods load last** — UI changes should override everything else
3. **Audio mods load before content mods** — prevents conflicts
4. **Total overhauls load first** — they change the foundation everything else builds on

TWMM allows drag-and-drop reordering. Use the “Groups” feature to save load order profiles for each wave.

#### Verifying Compatibility

- TWMM checks for known conflicts and shows warnings
- Cross-reference with `conflicts.yaml` for tracked issues
- If TWMM shows a conflict, check the resolution field in the mod entry or `conflicts.yaml`

#### Per-Wave Profiles

1. In TWMM, create a “Wave 0” group with those mods enabled and all others disabled
2. When moving to Wave 1, disable all Wave 0 mods first, then enable Wave 1 mods

3. This prevents cross-wave conflicts

### **Manual Installation (Without TWMM)**

1. Download mod .pack files
2. Place in steamapps/common/Total War THREE KINGDOMS/data/
3. Launch the game launcher
4. Go to “Mod Manager” tab
5. Enable mods in the correct order
6. Launch the game

“Note: The game’s built-in mod manager is less capable than TWMM. TWMM is strongly recommended.”